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India Monsoon Flash Floods Kill 26 in Kashmir, Nagaland, Assam; Pilgrimages Halted

IMD warns of six more days of extreme monsoon rain; more than 57,000 displaced in Assam

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(PHOTO: GETTYIMAGES.COM)

Flash floods and landslides triggered by the southwest monsoon killed at least 26 people across three Indian states between July 18 and 20, 2026, as India's national weather office warned Monday that active monsoon conditions are likely to persist across the Himalayan arc for another six to seven days. Rescue operations were underway in Jammu & Kashmir, Nagaland, and Assam simultaneously — a simultaneous multi-state deployment that illustrates both the geographic breadth of this year's monsoon surge and the limits of coordinated disaster response across terrain where landslides cut roads as fast as crews can clear them.

For hundreds of thousands of Hindu pilgrims, the disaster carried an additional and immediate consequence: authorities suspended three of northern India's most significant pilgrimages — the Amarnath Yatra, the Mata Vaishno Devi pilgrimage, and the Shri Shiv Khori pilgrimage — effective July 19, citing the [India Meteorological Department's adverse weather forecast](#) and refusing to commit to a resumption date until routes are formally declared safe.

The [IMD's July 20 press release](#) forecast active monsoon conditions likely to persist over northwest, east, and northeast India for the next six to seven days, with heavy to very heavy rainfall continuing over Jammu & Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh, and Uttarakhand through at least July 21.

Death Toll Across Kashmir Still Climbing as July Continues

Jammu & Kashmir sustained the heaviest losses. Rain-related incidents in the Poonch, Rajouri, and Doda districts killed at least 15 people over the weekend of July 18–19, with several others still missing as rescue teams raced against continuing rain and washed-out roads. Four additional deaths were confirmed in Jammu city on July 20, pushing the territory's two-day toll to at least 16.

The single worst concentration of casualties came from Surankote tehsil in Poonch district. The worst damage in Rajouri arrived not from a single catastrophic event but from the compounding effect of flash-flood volumes overwhelming drainage systems in developed areas — vehicles parked in zones considered safe under normal conditions were swept away or buried when overflowing rivers exceeded what overextended drainage infrastructure could handle. [Reuters confirmed](#) at least 15 killed in J&K and seven missing as of July 20.



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Army personnel and state emergency responders rescued multiple people from swollen rivers across J&K on July 19, including five children evacuated from a flooded stream near Churung village in Thanamandi and two youths rescued from a river island near Dhangri.

Jammu & Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah canceled a planned protest event in New Delhi and returned to Jammu's Civil Secretariat, where he [chaired a high-level emergency review meeting](#) to oversee the relief effort.

Nine Killed in Nagaland as Landslides Bury Homes in Mon District

In Nagaland's Mon district, landslides triggered by persistent heavy rain killed nine people and injured at least 15 others, with recovery operations continuing as of Monday. The slides struck Mon town at around 6:30 a.m. local time on July 19, burying a cluster of 10 to 15 homes after hours of sustained rain.

"We have recovered four of the eight bodies, and rescue work is ongoing," said Wennyei Konyak, the magistrate of Mon district, in a statement to AFP. Search-and-rescue teams from the State Disaster Response Force, police, [Assam Rifles](#), [the National Disaster Response Force](#), and local community members were deployed at sites where people remained trapped under debris.

Assam Displaces 57,000 as Army and Air Force Placed on Standby

Assam's flood toll stood at one confirmed death — in Sivasagar — as of July 20, but the displacement figures revealed a humanitarian situation of far greater scale: more than 57,100 people across seven districts were affected, with 14 relief camps and distribution centers operating across four districts. Some 440 displaced residents were sheltering in camps; roughly 3,600 more were receiving relief distribution.

The worst-hit district was Charaideo, with nearly 24,000 people affected, followed by Dhemaji with around 22,000 and Dibrugarh with approximately 4,000. The Burhidihing River was flowing above the danger mark at Chenimari in Dibrugarh district's Khowang area, and [298 villages remained inundated](#).

active across Sivasagar, Charaideo, and Jorhat districts.

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma confirmed the state had [requested the Indian Army and Indian Air Force](#) to remain on standby to support evacuation and rescue in Sivasagar, Charaideo, and Jorhat if the situation deteriorated further.

Three Pilgrimages Suspended and Highways Cut as Devotees Are Turned Back

The Amarnath Yatra — which drew more than 400,000 Hindu devotees in 2025 and more than 370,000 in the first weeks of the 2026 season before Monday's suspension — was halted on both its Pahalgam and Baltal routes effective July 19. The Mata Vaishno Devi pilgrimage in Jammu — which draws millions annually — was simultaneously suspended, as was the Shri Shiv Khori pilgrimage.

"Owing to the adverse weather forecast issued by the India Meteorological Department, the Shri Amarnath Ji Yatra has been temporarily suspended on both the Pahalgam and Baltal routes with effect from July 19, 2026, in the interest of the safety and well-being of all yatris," said [Divisional Commissioner Jammu Ramesh Kumar](#) in a statement.

All three pilgrimages will remain suspended until routes are formally declared safe — a determination that depends on both the end of heavy rain and the completion of road-clearance and safety inspection work by the Border Roads Organisation.

This is not the first time Amarnath has been suspended for flood risk. A cloudburst at the Amarnath cave shrine on July 8, 2022 killed 16 people and left more than 40 missing, leading to an immediate suspension; the [yatra was suspended again later that month](#) after more flash floods struck the mountain route. The 2022 precedent underscores that pilgrimage suspensions in Kashmir during monsoon season are not precautionary overreactions — they are responses to a documented, recurring hazard.

Road connectivity across affected districts was severely disrupted, with multiple highways blocked by landslide debris and communities temporarily cut off from relief supply lines.

Is Amarnath Yatra Suspended? What Pilgrims Need to Know Right Now

Authorities have suspended the Amarnath Yatra on both the Pahalgam route (also called Nunwan/Chandanwari) and the Baltal route, effective July 19, 2026. No pilgrims are being permitted to proceed toward the cave shrine from either base camp. Officials stated the pilgrimage will resume only after weather conditions improve and the routes are declared safe — no date has been given. [The Mata Vaishno Devi pilgrimage in Jammu is separately suspended](#) as well.

Shri Amarnath Ji Shrine Board before attempting to proceed.

IMD Forecasts Show Heavy Rain Continuing for Days Across the Region

India's Meteorological Department issued a press release on July 20 at 1:40 p.m. IST forecasting active monsoon conditions likely to persist over northwest, east, and northeast India for the next six to seven days. The department recorded extremely heavy rainfall — exceeding 210 millimeters in a 24-hour period ending at 8:30 a.m. IST on July 20 — over Uttarakhand and Meghalaya.

The highest single-station total recorded was 370 mm at Williamnagar in Assam and Meghalaya, followed by 220 mm at Shama in Uttarakhand, 200 mm at Siwan in Bihar, 150 mm at Tuli NSDMA AWS in Nagaland, and 90 mm at Rajouri in J&K.

Further extremely heavy rainfall was forecast for isolated locations in Jammu-Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh, and Uttarakhand on July 20 and 21, and for Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, Assam, and Meghalaya on July 20. The IMD forecast indicates [conditions in Kashmir are unlikely to improve](#) before July 22 at the earliest, with only brief thundershower spells expected from July 24 onward.

A separate July 19 advisory had already issued low-to-moderate flash-flood risk guidance for watersheds in J&K and Ladakh, Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Punjab, and Haryana-Chandigarh-Delhi through 11:30 a.m. IST on July 21.

Broader Climate Context: The Numbers Behind "Getting Worse"

The destruction across India's north and northeast reflects a pattern that climate scientists have been quantifying for decades, not merely observing. Published research establishes specific magnitudes that the current disaster fits into: a threefold rise in widespread extreme rainfall events across central India from 1950 to 2015, documented by Roxy et al. in [Nature Communications in 2017](#). A separate analysis found cloudburst frequency over the Himalayan and Western Ghats foothills rose approximately 50 percent between the 1981–2000 period and the 2001–2020 period.

The physical mechanism behind this trend is well-established: the Clausius-Clapeyron relation dictates that extreme single-day precipitation events intensify at roughly 7 percent per degree Celsius of warming, as a warmer atmosphere holds more moisture and releases it more intensely when convection triggers. The [IPCC Sixth Assessment Report](#) confirms this scaling globally. The Himalayas amplify this effect through orographic forcing — moisture-laden southwest monsoon winds rise as they encounter the Himalayan range, cool adiabatically, and release precipitation in concentrated bursts on the windward slopes. The range itself functions as a precipitation concentrator.

rainfall across much of the region for 2026, and yet the early season has already produced multi-state disasters. "A below-normal monsoon does not mean a safer monsoon," [ICIMOD scientists warned in a July 7 statement](#), noting that the documented pattern involves longer dry spells punctuated by sudden, intense bursts — conditions that saturate slopes and overwhelm drainage in concentrated events rather than spreading rain more evenly.

The 2025 monsoon season reinforced this pattern at scale: it produced 108 percent of long-period average rainfall nationally while simultaneously recording the worst northwest India season since 2001 (127 percent of LPA in that region), and the [2025 Kishtwar district cloudburst](#) in J&K killed 68 people in a single event in August of that year.

India's response to the structural risk has included the Mission Mausam framework approved by the Union Cabinet in September 2024, which committed approximately ₹2,000 crore over two years to expand the national monsoon observation network, including [87 additional Doppler weather radars](#) that will grow the network from 39 to about 126 stations by the end of 2026. Better data does not prevent rain. It gives disaster managers more time to prepare — and gives pilgrims, travelers, and residents more time to get to higher ground.

Rescue Operations Scale Up as Missing Remain Unaccounted For

Multi-agency rescue efforts were active across all three states as of July 20. In Nagaland's Mon district, SDRF, NDRF, police, Assam Rifles, and local volunteers were conducting search operations for bodies and survivors still buried in landslide debris, with an unknown number yet to be recovered.

In Assam, rail communications in flood-hit areas were disrupted by inundation, compounding logistical challenges for relief supply chains. Crops across 3,874 hectares were damaged, and more than 37,558 domestic animals and poultry were affected by the inundation — particularly in Dhemaji district. [The Assam State Disaster Management Authority](#) confirmed these figures in its daily flood report.

At least seven people remained missing in Poonch and Rajouri as of the latest available reports. With the IMD projecting heavy rain to continue through at least July 22 in J&K, and active monsoon conditions forecast to persist across the northeast for the remainder of the week, the official casualty count is likely to rise.

Frequently Asked Questions

Is Amarnath Yatra suspended, and when will it resume?

Yes. The Amarnath Yatra was suspended on July 19, 2026 on both the Pahalgam and Baltal routes, following IMD warnings of heavy rainfall and flash-flood risk. Authorities have not announced a resumption date. The pilgrimage will resume only after routes are formally declared safe following a weather clearance and road-safety inspection. The

Which states were affected by India's July 2026 monsoon floods, and how many people have died?

Flash floods and landslides between July 18 and 20, 2026 killed at least 26 people across three states: at least 16 in Jammu & Kashmir (Poonch, Rajouri, Doda, and Jammu city), nine in Nagaland's Mon district, and one in Assam's Sivasagar district. More than 57,000 people were displaced in Assam alone. At least seven people remained missing in J&K as of July 20, and the death toll was expected to rise as rescue operations continued. [Al Jazeera](#) and Reuters independently confirmed these figures.

Are India's monsoon floods getting worse, and is this season unusual?

The scientific evidence is specific: published research documents a threefold rise in widespread extreme rainfall events across central India from 1950 to 2015, and Himalayan cloudburst frequency rose approximately 50 percent between the 1981–2000 and 2001–2020 periods. The physical driver is well-understood: each degree of warming allows the atmosphere to hold roughly 7 percent more moisture, [intensifying extreme precipitation events](#) even when overall seasonal rainfall remains average or below normal. What is unusual about 2026 is the combination of a nationally below-normal monsoon season with severe localized early-season events — a paradox that ICIMOD researchers explicitly warned about in July 2026, noting that longer dry spells followed by intense bursts are increasingly the dominant Himalayan pattern.

How long will the extreme monsoon rain continue in J&K and the northeast?

IMD's July 20 press release forecast active monsoon conditions over northwest, east, and northeast India for six to seven more days. Heavy to extremely heavy rainfall was forecast for J&K, Himachal Pradesh, and Uttarakhand through July 21, with [conditions in Kashmir](#) unlikely to see meaningful improvement until after July 22. Some reduction in rainfall intensity is forecast after July 26 for parts of the region. Residents in low-lying and landslide-prone areas across the Himalayan arc have been advised to remain on high alert through at least July 24.

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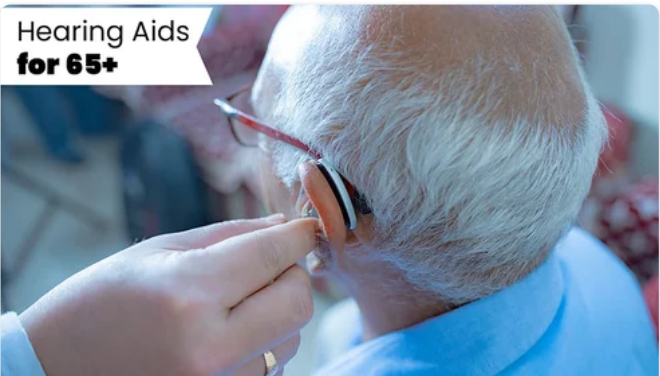
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